Nikhil Kamath x Kumar Birla | People by WTF Ep #5

[Speaker 2] (0:00 - 1:39)

If you had one chance to redo life today, starting afresh. You're not Kumar Mangalam Birla, but you're just Kumar, starting off. What business would you put the money in?

Firstly, thank you for doing this. So the format of this is very casual. It's typically a bunch of friends sitting and chatting.

How it started was I used to have a few people over for dinner in Bangalore on the weekends. And some of the conversations we had were so interesting that a lot of people would go back home from dinner and say that, you know, I wish more people could be a part of that. Like extremely contrarian opinions on different viewpoints.

So stuff like that.

[Speaker 1] (1:39 - 1:40)

That sounds interesting.

[Speaker 2] (1:40 - 2:29)

Yeah. So this is all in like an effort to help many people who could learn from your own journey. Most of our audience are entrepreneurs and wannabe entrepreneurs who are quite young in the age bracket of I would say 15 to 35, 40.

And from starting at 15. Yeah, very young. And a lot of them want to be entrepreneurs and they could learn a lot from your own journey.

So if I could start at the beginning, wherever you want to talk and think of it as a two way conversation. If you feel like you want to ask me anything, feel free to ask me anything about anything and I will try and answer as honestly as I can. Done.

Okay.

[Speaker 1] (2:29 - 2:31)

Mind will end up asking you more than you asked me.

[Speaker 2] (2:33 - 2:45)

So tell us a little bit about the early years. First vivid memory that comes to you from childhood. Start from there.

[Speaker 1] (2:47 - 3:26)

Yeah, so very happy childhood to say the least. Very secure, lots of laughter, a great sense of positivity, high energy, you know, very close family ties. And where was this?

So a part of it was in Calcutta, right? The rest of it was in Bombay. But, you know, on holidays, I always went back to Calcutta because the larger family was there.

So for me, childhood means Calcutta much more than Bombay. It's very secure. I think it just gives you an anchor and very strong roots.

[Speaker 2] (3:26 - 3:29)

And what era was this? Era?

[Speaker 1] (3:30 - 3:38)

What generation? We moved to Bombay in 69, I think. So at least for the next 20 years after that.

Right.

[Speaker 2] (3:40 - 3:45)

Leading up to this, I've watched all your interviews, everything from...

[Speaker 1] (3:45 - 3:45)

There aren't too many.

[Speaker 2] (3:46 - 3:47)

Yeah, there's so few.

[Speaker 1] (3:47 - 3:48)

Yeah.

[Speaker 2] (3:49 - 4:11)

There's very few about you. There are a couple about you acquiring a company, entering the ARC business, talking about Ratan Tata at his demise, stuff like that. But the one interview I found of you was 26 years ago.

I think Simi Agarwal. What led you to do that?

[Speaker 1] (4:12 - 4:18)

I just thought it was interesting. I don't know. She's a friend.

So also couldn't say no, to be honest.

[Speaker 2] (4:18 - 4:18)

Right.

[Speaker 1] (4:19 - 4:22)

Like the format. It was kind of fun.

[Speaker 2] (4:22 - 4:23)

Yeah.

[Speaker 1] (4:24 - 4:26)

Is it still there on YouTube?

[Speaker 2] (4:26 - 4:26)

Of course. Yeah.

[Speaker 1] (4:27 - 4:34)

That was very early years. That's when my father had just passed away. Less than a year ago.

Right. So life was different then.

[Speaker 2] (4:35 - 4:46)

Right. You looked very fashionable in that interview. You had like this double-breasted.

I would say what? Brownish?

[Speaker 1] (4:46 - 4:47)

Camel colour, I think.

[Speaker 2] (4:47 - 5:00)

Camel colour jacket. This is not something people talk about. Like if you were to tell me what is the, ask me, what is the difference between camel, brown, suede, and I don't know, nude colour, I wouldn't know.

[Speaker 1] (5:00 - 5:01)

Nor would I.

[Speaker 2] (5:01 - 5:02)

Yeah?

[Speaker 1] (5:02 - 5:03)

No, I wouldn't.

[Speaker 2] (5:03 - 5:06)

Is there a creative element in you hiding something?

[Speaker 1] (5:06 - 5:19)

Of course. I think I'm essentially a creative person. And for me, the most creative thing you can do is build or run a business.

I think there's so much of creativity that goes into that. Don't you think so?

[Speaker 2] (5:23 - 5:36)

To a certain extent, yes. But beyond a certain extent for a business that has reached the scale that yours has, is it creativity as much as it is risk-taking ability and efficiency?

[Speaker 1] (5:38 - 6:18)

Risk-taking and efficiency, of course, is always a part of any business. I think as a business grows larger and scales up, you know, you need to be more and more creative because all the sort of low-hanging fruit are done with. And you've got to keep creating value.

So I think you actually need to be, that's when management turns from being a science into an art. And therefore, I think that phase of a company's life, when you've got scale, when you're maybe the largest or second largest player, you're required to think really out of the box. So more creativity required, I would think.

[Speaker 2] (6:20 - 6:26)

So grew up in Calcutta and then Mumbai, which school did you go to? Do you remember anything from those times?

[Speaker 1] (6:27 - 7:16)

I went to Campion. I remember school quite well, very tough and very strict environment. So a little different, not too much of fun for a better part of it.

I think we all enjoyed, you know, class 9 and 10, because then you grew up and you have your

own sort of, you know, you're independent of school authority. But good fun. Very simple, very cosmopolitan.

You know, I mean, at our time, at that time, it was all very simple stuff. Excited to run and get an ice cream during recess, that kind of thing. Getting back from not getting the right book and not wearing the right kind of shoe.

That was the kind of school that it was.

[Speaker 2] (7:16 - 7:17)

Were you a good student?

[Speaker 1] (7:18 - 7:30)

I was a good student for a big part of, I think till grade 8, after which I slipped considerably. I don't know why. But yeah, up until class 8, very good.

[Speaker 2] (7:32 - 7:38)

Did everyone in school already associate you with the Birla and all that comes with it?

[Speaker 1] (7:39 - 8:21)

You know, like I said, it was a very, very cosmopolitan bunch of students from all walks of life. We were also quite innocent and naive because we didn't have social media to spoil us, for example. So quite in our own cocoon.

Of course, people knew the family name and all of that, but it really didn't affect anyone in any which way. I was just one out of a class of 40, let's say. So that was sort of the good part about school.

You didn't get any special attention at all, which was nice.

[Speaker 2] (8:23 - 8:38)

Did media work differently back then when you say your classmates did not know or the school did not treat you differently even though you were the in a way scion of one of the business families of India?

[Speaker 1] (8:39 - 8:45)

There was hardly any media then, Nikhil. I mean, you had Doordarshan for the most of my years at school.

[Speaker 2] (8:46 - 8:46)

In the 70s.

[Speaker 1] (8:47 - 9:15)

In the 70s and early 80s. So it was, media wasn't a big part of our lives. Maybe more radio, but nothing that was, you know, intrusive or sensational.

It was all very sort of day to day kind of news or world news or political stuff from what I remember. Nothing on business families or nothing that, you know, made you stand apart.

[Speaker 2] (9:16 - 9:32)

Do you have any insight into psychologically how you were as a young boy? What your attachment styles were? Did you get along more with your mother or your father?

What were your aspirations back then and your fears back then?

[Speaker 1] (9:33 - 12:25)

Wow, you really are getting me to go back in time. Like I said, it's been family for me all along. You know, I think strong family ties makes you a different kind of a person.

I've always been closer to my mother but was very strongly bonded with my father as well. So in our generation, chances were that there was a distance between a father and a son. That was almost kind of, you know, the done thing or the norm.

But obviously we were very connected. We all lived together. I think I didn't have any fears or I didn't have any very complex thoughts or feelings to be honest.

When I look at children of that age now, their lives are so much more complex, right? They know about every student in every school in Bombay and what happened. I mean, if something unusual out of the way was to happen, let's say a kid was caught taking drugs, the whole of the city's children would know about it.

Although it wasn't in their school maybe. For us, it was one class above us, one class below us. That's all we knew.

We were quite happy with ourselves. So I don't remember having any kind of fears. The only fear was about exams maybe, as simple as that.

I was always a last minute student and got into trouble with my father for that. So that was perhaps the only fear. Aspirations at that time, again, you know, we were so unexposed in many ways.

So it was all about school. It was about school. It was about, you know, you hung out with some

friends, lots of cousins, not too many aspirations at that point in life, to be really honest.

Just, you know, almost one exam to the other, so to speak. They were the sort of bookends of life at that point in time. So it was quite a, you know, uncomplicated, easy childhood.

I don't remember feeling any kind of complex, inferior or superior. I don't feel, I never felt any jealousy or envy or nothing negative at all. I think it was always, that was always the atmosphere at home as well.

A little stress because I created that stress for myself. I wanted to always do well. Not that it was, you know, trust on me, but that was an expectation I had for myself.

That perhaps was the only stress at that point in time.

[Speaker 2] (12:26 - 12:37)

If you had to go back in time and think of the most stressful thing that happened to you between the grade of five and 10, is there a memory that pops up?

[Speaker 1] (12:37 - 13:18)

I think the ICSE exams, they were quite the great and very hyped up, very scary for most of us. That by far was the most scary thing up until class 10. Otherwise, I mean, it was just a very simple childhood.

We grew up a lot of cousins together, you know, lots of fun. And I mean, I studied as well. Soon after that, I started to study for my CA.

But up until 10, it was only about the most worrisome thing in life was examinations.

[Speaker 2] (13:21 - 14:22)

A lot of what we are today, I'm a psychology fan. So I like reading books on psychology, not that I know too much, but the little bit that I know tells me that a lot of how we are today are determined and defined by events that happened in that duration of our life. And I've said this before, but I find that a lot of very successful people today are building on top of some kind of confrontation, avoiding confrontation, vicariously viewing confrontation or something shameful that happened.

It could be as simple as a teacher slapping a child. How that shame is felt by the child and how you build around it and what it becomes when you're an adult is a completely different thing. Did you have any stark moments like that which went into defining who you are as a person today?

[Speaker 1] (14:22 - 14:22)

At school?

[Speaker 2] (14:23 - 14:24)

Or at home?

[Speaker 1] (14:25 - 15:55)

You know, there was nothing at school. I did get whacked around a couple of times by teachers that was more about, you know, talking in between classes and stuff like that. Nothing that left any kind of impact at all.

The impact at home was huge. So my grandfather was alive, great-grandfather was alive at the time. My grandfather and father were obviously there, all three working.

So high energy, I mean, I used to see all of them. There was so much to learn just from a chat like this on the dining table. A lot of perspective about life.

I think that a lot of my self-assuredness comes from that phase of my life because they were encouraging, happy to let you explore. At the same time, there was a sense of doing one's duty and doing it well. Discipline was something that, you know, I remember as being a hallmark of the family in a nice way.

So yes, I think those years, the school years, influences at home were much stronger. And I agree with you. I think that those years actually shape you to become the adult that you become.

Very secure, like I said. So I think self-assuredness comes from a sense of great security. Yeah, it's a very happy time.

[Speaker 2] (15:55 - 16:02)

Do you remember how each of them were different from the other? Grandfather from father to great-grandfather?

[Speaker 1] (16:02 - 16:15)

You know, they were all products of different timeframes. So my great-grandfather was, you know, pretty much a product of pre-independent India.

[Speaker 2] (16:16 - 16:16)

Right.

[Speaker 1] (16:16 - 16:27)

My grandfather, a time of scarcity. So that's the time that he kind of represented, the time that he was active in his career.

[Speaker 2] (16:27 - 16:30)

Scarcity by virtue of India flirting with socialism?

[Speaker 1] (16:32 - 16:39)

Socialism. Also, we were obviously, you know, at a nascent stage of being a developing country.

[Speaker 2] (16:39 - 16:39)

Right.

[Speaker 1] (16:42 - 17:40)

So, I mean, you sort of lived within your means, you didn't spend too much. It was very different. The mindscape at that time was very different.

My father grew up in liberalized India. And I think, you know, the businesses that you run also shape you as a person. It's not just the other way around.

So all of them are pretty distinct. My father was more expansive in his view on business. My great-grandfather, of course, played a very important role in just building Indian industry at the grassroots level, just pre and post independence.

My grandfather was more conservative and he was a numbers person. So he drove his businesses through numbers, so to speak. So pretty different, all of them.

Interesting.

[Speaker 2] (17:41 - 17:50)

So when your grandfather was around in a time of scarcity in the country overall, when he saw that change, did he change?

[Speaker 1] (17:51 - 18:52)

No, he remained very much the same. He passed about five years ago and I happened to go and open his cupboard after that, looking for something. He had five kurtas and dhotis and three suits and that was about it.

Just to get him to make a new suit for himself was like a major project for my grandmother and my aunt. That's the kind of, you know, life that they were used to. That's the kind of life that we got exposed to through them.

So I don't know many people who have been told to go back into the room and put off the light or the fan. That for us at that time was pretty kind of common because it was expected that when

you leave the room, you put on the fan, you put off the light. So we had a brush with that also since we were growing up then.

And that in itself is a big piece of learning.

[Speaker 2] (18:53 - 18:57)

And your father, very different to your grandfather?

[Speaker 1] (18:58 - 19:39)

Very different. The values pretty much remained the same, but I think he was more of a risk taker, wanting to expand his business outside the country more aggressively. It was also a different India, right?

So you could take bigger bets than say my grandfather could. Didn't have the opportunity then in any case. So yeah, they were all very different people.

I had a great rapport with all of them. Every equation was very different as you can imagine. So yeah, a lot of love and a lot of good cheer and laughter.

[Speaker 2] (19:41 - 19:43)

Closest to your grandfather and then your father?

[Speaker 1] (19:47 - 20:49)

Difficult to say actually, Nikhil. Very different equations with all of them. My great-grandfather at that time when I was growing up, I spent a couple of hours every Sunday with him.

So for me, he was just my best friend. I'd drag him for a movie and he'd take me to the aquarium. That was pretty much the only thing you could do in Bombay at the time.

My grandfather was doting. He just loved me immensely. You know, just an ocean of love, both of them.

My father was a tough taskmaster. So when I started going to work, I saw an avatar of him that I really hadn't experienced before. Which was different.

You know, I think when in our company people come to me and complain about being under a tough boss, I'm thinking in my mind, you know, they have no idea what a tough boss can be all about.

[Speaker 2] (20:49 - 20:51)

Can you elaborate? How was he tough?

[Speaker 1] (20:54 - 21:28)

Because you just had to be on top of things all the time. You couldn't nap at the wheel, even for a minute in the day. You'd get caught out in some way or the other.

So he was just very demanding. He also gave me a lot of space, I must say. Much more than, let's say, fathers at that time did.

But he was also very demanding. And, you know, he was very driven and very demanding of himself as well. So I think that was fair.

[Speaker 2] (21:31 - 21:33)

What age were you when he passed away?

[Speaker 1] (21:34 - 21:49)

I was 28. Nikhil, he was 52. So obviously died very young and tragically.

I think that shaped all of our lives differently after his passing.

[Speaker 2] (21:50 - 22:14)

What did you feel when he passed away? I'll give you a personal story. My father passed away like 10, 11 months ago.

What are your thoughts as soon as something like that happens, when it's unexpected? And how do your thoughts evolve after one year, two years and five years? What was the first thing that happened to a 28 year old Kumar when father abruptly passed away?

[Speaker 1] (22:15 - 23:48)

No, so he was suffering from cancer for two years. It's just that, you know, the cancer kind of galloped. We thought he had 10 years, he suddenly took ill and things took a turn for the worse.

The first thing actually was a sense of relief for him. Because he'd gone through so much pain for those two years that I really couldn't see him suffer anymore. It was very evident that he wouldn't be able to lead a normal life again.

And he wouldn't be happy not being able to do that. So I really think the first feeling was one of relief for him. Then you start to feel this emptiness.

I never really thought this would happen. You did feel a sense of loss. You also started to feel a sense of big responsibility that, you know, falls on you.

And I think work was my biggest escape. I got involved with that, wanted to also give back to him

in some way by carrying forward his name, his legacy and doing the work that, you know, he had wanted to do but couldn't complete. And I think that was a huge, sort of, like I said, an escape, working very long hours, but doing things that, you know, he wanted to do but couldn't.

And that kind of, I think, blunted the, you know, this sense of emptiness to a large extent.

[Speaker 2] (23:50 - 24:48)

If you could change one thing about your father while he was alive, one character trait. Most people, when we speak about people who have passed away, we have to euphemize the bad and embellish the good almost, right? All humans have plus, plus, plus and minus, minus, minus.

And I find it hard to do it today because it's only been 10, 11 months. It's probably too soon. But if I have to tomorrow figure out why I am the way I am and what traits I inherited from my father, I'll have to, like, at some point be objective about this whole thing.

So if you had to change something about your father vicariously living like him while he was alive, what would you change?

[Speaker 1] (24:49 - 25:44)

You know, retrospection, Nikhil, is a very powerful tool. So it's all very well for me to say that he could have been different in this way and that way. But I mean, what, at the most, I could say that he could have spent more time with us.

But you know, he was in a phase where he was building his career. I went through that phase myself. And I know what the pressures of that phase of one's career can be like.

I don't think that I would have wanted him to be any different. You know, all of us have our rough edges. We have our pet peeves.

He had his as well. But I think he was a good man. He was a good father, protected us, pushed me quite a lot because I think I needed to be pushed at that point in time.

[Speaker 2] (25:44 - 25:45)

Are you like him?

[Speaker 1] (25:46 - 27:23)

I'm very different from him. We are all pretty different people, actually, I think. Circumstances, I think, you know, the shape of your own childhood, people in your life, everything is different.

I was always also very encouraged by everyone to be my own person whilst I was growing up. That was a constant refrain, you know, be your own person. My great grandfather used to tell me

that a lot.

You know, I think I was in class five or six, and I remember him saying, you know, you've got to take your own decisions now. Any important decision concerning your life should be yours. And he'd come to Bombay every couple of months.

And he'd always ask me this, have you started taking your own decisions? Or are your parents taking your decisions for you? You know, in that kind of an environment, think about it.

You're empowered, right? You're given the currency to make important decisions and be, you know, an independent decision maker. I think that was just terrific.

I mean, that worked really well for me. I always had a mind of my own. My father knew that.

He really pushed me hard, like I said, and I think, you know, I'm really grateful to him for that. I was sort of a bit of a dreamer then. And that drive, you know, was required.

[Speaker 2] (27:23 - 27:24)

And what did you dream about?

[Speaker 1] (27:24 - 27:28)

Which he pushed me into, he almost pushed me off the precipice, so to speak.

[Speaker 2] (27:29 - 27:33)

And when you say dreamer, what did you dream of doing? What does the alternate life look like?

[Speaker 1] (27:33 - 28:51)

Nothing. I had no other plan. I always wanted to join him at work.

I didn't have an alternative, to be honest, but luckily for me, I had no other, you know, sort of burning desire to do something else or some great talent. This was something that I'd grown up seeing around me. I'd always been fascinated by.

And so it was pretty much taken for granted. And that's what I actually wanted to do as well. I just found the conversations that the three of them had quite interesting always.

You know, the way they spoke about a business situation, setting up a new business about their people. They also had their own teams, all three of them. And their teams were also quite different from each other.

In some way, the reflection of, you know, the leader of the three of them. So business always fascinated me. You know, so I don't think that there was no issue there about, I want to do this,

but they want me to do that.

Or, you know, I have a great talent, which I'm not able to pursue because I have to join the family in business. That phase, luckily, didn't happen with me at all.

[Speaker 2] (28:52 - 29:46)

This is something very interesting about attachment types. I've always tried to figure out mine and I feel like I'm avoidant attached. I'll give you an example.

If three children were left alone in a room and their mothers leave the room, the children start crying. The mother of the first child comes back and coddles the child. The child stops crying immediately.

The mother of the second child comes and coddles the child. The child takes a certain amount of time of crying, after which the child stops crying. The third child, the mother leaves the room, does not cry.

And the mother comes back into the room, acts like it doesn't care and does not give attention or acknowledge the mother's presence. If you had to put yourself in one of those boxes, which one would it be?

[Speaker 1] (29:46 - 29:47)

As a parent or as a child?

[Speaker 2] (29:47 - 29:48)

As a child.

[Speaker 1] (29:49 - 31:04)

You know, since we were quite a few members in the family, my grandparents, my aunts, two aunts, those are my father's sisters, who have been very close to my grandparents, parents who were a very sort of integral part of my life. So you kind of, and my great grandfather, my parents, of course, you know, each one had their own kind of, like I was saying, pet peeve. They were all different personalities.

Sometimes, when I look back now, I almost feel that it was choreographed, you know, one was being a good cop, one was being a bad cop. But, you know, net-net, that worked quite well, actually. If, let's say, I had a parent who believed in, let's say, in tough love, and no one in the family to soften that for me, I think that would have been much tougher.

But when you have, when you're attached to so many people in the family, it gives you a broader base, a broader emotional base. So it worked as a team, I think, like a pack. And that's true for all

of us, I think.

We all kind of, you're part of a family, obviously, like a pack.

[Speaker 2] (31:04 - 31:17)

In love today, is it like that? In a relationship where you're in love with the other person, are you very emotionally, availably attached to the person?

[Speaker 1] (31:17 - 31:18)

Who, me?

[Speaker 2] (31:18 - 31:18)

Yeah.

[Speaker 1] (31:20 - 31:26)

Very easily, emotionally available, yes. But to a very few people.

[Speaker 2] (31:26 - 31:28)

Who comes on top of that hierarchy?

[Speaker 1] (31:29 - 31:36)

The children, of course, I think that's true. One of them? All three of them.

I have a different equation with all three of them.

[Speaker 2] (31:37 - 31:37)

Right.

[Speaker 1] (31:39 - 31:57)

They were all three very special kids. I'm sure every father thinks that about his kids. I definitely do about mine.

But, you know, emotional availability, I think, has to be restricted to just a very few people. It can damage you otherwise.

[Speaker 2] (31:58 - 32:00)

How many people do you think that should be?

[Speaker 1] (32:01 - 32:17)

In that, the lucky five or six, I'd say six or seven. Right. I wouldn't want to be emotionally available more than that.

How would you? Isn't that a very taxing thing?

[Speaker 2] (32:17 - 32:50)

It is. Yeah. I don't think I'm very emotionally available.

It's a big flaw of mine. I didn't, this is not a self actualization thing, but I realized it, but I've had multiple people tell me I'm emotionally available. And today I'm at that place where if more than two or three people tell me something, at some point I have to acknowledge it.

Acknowledge it not outwardly, but to myself. Maybe there's something to it. So I think I'm a fairly emotionally unavailable person.

[Speaker 1] (32:51 - 32:55)

What makes you like that? Actually, what's the problem in being like that?

[Speaker 2] (32:56 - 33:35)

Yeah, I feel like my hierarchy, they say whatever's on top of your list of hierarchies that you believe in is God for you. I feel like my list of hierarchies might be slightly different from somebody aspiring to a very balanced life. I'm in that phase of life where balance is not the ultimate goal, but maybe stupidly, I have my own little qualms and ambitions that give me short term validation and I chase them.

And maybe that makes me emotionally unavailable.

[Speaker 1] (33:35 - 33:39)

You're saying that this is about work-life balance? Or in what way do you mean that?

[Speaker 2] (33:39 - 34:11)

I feel like balance between everything, not just work and life outside of work, but the philosophical definition of balance, I think, is a balance between self-actualization, spirituality, figuring out your place in the ecosystem, where the world is. I think it's much broader. I don't think I play any part in that or I spend enough time dwelling on that.

Even the work-life balance, I don't really have it. I'm working all the time.

[Speaker 1] (34:11 - 34:16)

Yeah, and I don't think I can ever. I don't think I'm made like that.

[Speaker 2] (34:18 - 34:21)

But isn't that one of the things you wanted to change about your father?

[Speaker 1] (34:22 - 35:25)

My father? No, not really. I mean, why would you want to change anything about anyone?

I'm saying that today when I'm 57. I didn't feel that when I was at your age. But honestly that, I mean, the only thing I can think of is, I wish he'd spent more time with us.

But after having been through that phase where you're intensely involved in, you know, growing your business, you're on a very steep learning curve. I pretty much understand his predicament. You know, it is about how you balance time between work and family.

It's as simple as that. Other than that, I don't think that I would have liked him to be, you know, different in any way. Now, I don't see why, what would you have liked?

I know it's still a little raw for you, but anything about your dad that you would have liked to be different?

[Speaker 2] (35:26 - 35:44)

Yeah, I feel like it is a bit raw because it's not been a year yet. But I feel like he would, I would wish for him to have been more transient in his belief systems, even more than he already was.

[Speaker 1] (35:45 - 35:50)

Like you said, That's quite deeply. So in what way?

[Speaker 2] (35:51 - 36:41)

He was unwilling to change many of the belief systems that were inculcated into him very early. And I think he would have been a happier person if he had allowed for them to change. Like, I can like really go into this.

For example? Even the construct of marriage or the traditional societal construct of marriage. I feel like another version of it might have made it better for him.

I don't mean another person, but another version. A lot of the things in life are not voluntary choices that we are making.

[Speaker 1] (36:42 - 36:43)

They can't be.

[Speaker 2] (36:45 - 37:15)

Reason in itself is not organic. I feel like the world tells us what is right or wrong. And we conform more often than not, because not conforming is a lot more work than conforming.

And I think he did conform in many ways. And I wish he kind of like questioned not his choices, but societal norms more so he could have made choices.

[Speaker 1] (37:15 - 37:20)

So would that have impacted your and your brother's life in a different way or?

[Speaker 2] (37:20 - 37:22)

It might have, but I feel like...

[Speaker 1] (37:22 - 37:26)

You think he would have been a happier person? Is that the space you come from?

[Speaker 2] (37:26 - 37:50)

Yeah. I feel like we wrongly take the burden of responsibility for things that we actually don't control, but we think we can control. If each person finds what makes him happy and he's true to that, I would suspect the other people who love him will be happier by virtue of that.

[Speaker 1] (37:53 - 39:43)

That's a deep one again. Yeah. No, actually, when I think about it, the only thing that made my dad worry about me was the fact that I didn't always conform.

And that sort of, you know, got him really worried, especially when it came to airing my opinions about people most often. He didn't think it was a good idea to have strong views on people, issues and situations, especially in the family or, you know, home context. And I was always very liberal with my views.

That's just the DNA, I guess, that I've been born with. And he was always a little on the edge because of that. A little careful about, you know, what is he going to say next?

And I wasn't particularly, you know, careful about who I'm saying something to. If I didn't agree with you, I could be pretty opinionated and come across as being, you know, very apparent that I don't agree. That could be a relative, that could be a guest, it could be a friend of the family's.

That's something that he couldn't quite understand. Right. Conforming is something that it is a

very sort of double-edged sword, right?

So you have to kind of strike a balance. I think the pressure to perform or conform on your generation is much less than it was on us. But to my generation, Which I think is, you know, huge.

[Speaker 2] (39:44 - 40:02)

But I think my generation being woke is also conforming to being woke. I don't think anybody has thought deeply enough about the contrarian viewpoints of the prior generation that we are taking. We are woke today because it's cool to be woke.

[Speaker 1] (40:02 - 40:50)

So you're saying that being woke is not really rooted in, you know, actual belief about something. It's just about being cool and being, going with the tide. Yeah.

That you will, I think you'll always have a majority of people who are like that. I mean, you know, that's something that's not going to change. Not in your generation, not in the generation after that.

But I think that not being able to conform in some ways gives you more choices, right? I mean, it gives you more latitude in the choices you make about, say, career, about so many things. Life is much easier when the need to conform is much lower.

[Speaker 2] (40:51 - 41:14)

It's like wine. Every year of wine, a certain vintage of wine has a certain characteristic. I feel like the mask of wokeness is my generation's characteristic.

And the default setting is the mask. And it's the easier setting. So nobody really has to question why we are woke.

[Speaker 1] (41:14 - 41:47)

Yeah, but I think that people, with people you interact with, you know, fairly closely, the mask will always fall. If someone's advocating something just to be woke and not because they believe in it, you know, that mask always falls. And, you know, a lot of people, most people want to conform.

They want to be part of the crowd and swim with the tide. So that's not, I don't find that. Unusual.

Is there something... What are you woke about? You, you ask for this...

[Speaker 2] (41:47 - 41:48)

What is the mask I've put on?

[Speaker 1] (41:48 - 41:52)

Not the mask. What do you actually woke about deeply? If anything...

[Speaker 2] (41:52 - 43:10)

What do I really care about? I feel like a lot of successful people like yourself would have thought a certain thing at a certain point of time in life and voiced it. It might be your family legacy.

It might be the tenets of the Birla family. With time, we buy into this philosophy so deeply that we lose all ability to tweak, nudge, change it. If people were allowed to change their minds more often without judgment, it's something I think will help humans evolve faster.

If I believed in something five years ago, and I changed my mind about it drastically today, the term society would give it is hypocrisy. The real term that should be attached to it, I think is evolution. And we should be all more welcoming of people changing their viewpoints and where they stand in society about different things.

I think it just speedens up the rate of evolution of society.

[Speaker 1] (43:12 - 44:34)

You know, I think that's a feeling that every generation feels. So if that makes you feel any better. I've never been someone who's overly concerned about what people say.

In fact, that's, you know, I grew up being told that, you know, must be careful. Like I said, I was quite open about, quite strong about my opinions on things and people. And my friends, my cousin would tell me that you don't seem to care about what other people are saying.

Look at what he's saying. It's just something that doesn't affect me. It never has.

You know, I mean, of course, one understands one's responsibilities and duties and all of that. And as long as you're doing good with that, other people's opinions have never mattered to me. Other than, you know, my own inner circle.

Not good or bad or right or wrong. It's just the way I've been. And I think that has been very liberating for me.

That takes a huge pressure off you. And that comes from, you know, an inner conviction. It's not because I want to project that or want to be like that.

It's just the way, you know, I've always been. And I think that's worked to my advantage.

[Speaker 2] (44:36 - 44:52)

Why the conscious decision to not speak publicly about what you're thinking? I think you barely have. Like I was saying, the last real interview I watched was 26 years ago.

Why is that?

[Speaker 1] (44:53 - 46:22)

You know, I'm pretty much consciously stayed away from the media. I don't think that my job requires me to be in people's faces all the time. And personally, I'm a private person.

I don't, I'm not very sort of keen on sharing things about my personal life or, you know, I'd rather keep all of that, my personal thoughts to myself. That's pretty much it. There's no other reason for that.

You have platforms to express your opinions if you want to, right? Whether it's at work or whether it's with the government or whether it's your family. And rather than speak about it to people at large through the media, I'd rather speak about it at an appropriate forum or an appropriate platform.

It could be a dinner table conversation. So I've never really shied away from, like I said, from speaking my mind. If it's something that really matters to me or bothers me, never worried about becoming unpopular on account of that or, you know, kind of rubbing someone the wrong way if it comes from a place of conviction.

But it doesn't have to be something that's known to the whole world. It's something that I think needs to be spoken of to the appropriate audience.

[Speaker 2] (46:23 - 46:49)

If you had zero fear, like I'm scared of so many things, right? Like I'm scared of judgment online, I'm scared of perception, government, regulator, this, that, the other, like a hundred different things. If you were scared of nothing and you had to say one thing that society needs to hear, but nobody's saying it, what would it be?

[Speaker 1] (46:51 - 46:53)

What would it be for you? Give me an example.

[Speaker 2] (46:54 - 47:08)

I feel like men's mental health is as important to society as anything else. And we should give it the place and weightage that it deserves. Your turn.

[Speaker 1] (47:11 - 51:11)

Yeah, no, I think that, you know, equality in terms of, let's say there's a marriage. You know, I've seen this so often, girl's side, boy's side, and the whole society constructed on that. What is expected of the boy's side?

What is so much more expectation on the girl's side? That kind of equality is something that I think we need to, you know, strive to make a change with its mindset. Mindsets, it's about tradition sometimes.

Sometimes it's just the way people are. But I think that that's such an important role in our society. You know, it has so many good and bad consequences.

It would be good for people to speak about that, create awareness around that. You know, for example, for a lot of parents, boy's parents asking for, daughter's parents, boy's parents asking for dowry is something that's quite normal. So, you know, it's like, what's wrong with it?

Some of these, I think, require radical change. And someone has to start to talk about them and create awareness. That's something that I feel quite strongly about, because I just think that, you know, there are so many people who are indebted for their whole life because they spent so much on getting their daughter married.

Not in our society, but in a lot of societies that you wouldn't even imagine, you know, things like this happening. That kind of thing makes me feel like it needs to be talked about by opinion makers, mindsets change, long process. But that's something that would bother me.

Interesting, it shapes. That's how, you know, society at that level gets shaped. That's how family units get shaped.

I remember just a few days ago, we run this scholarship in my father's name. And it was our 25th year. And some of the scholars who've been scholars over the years were talking about it.

One girl said, I come from a very conservative family. We didn't have finances to educate both me and my brother. My parents obviously chose to educate my brother.

And were it not for the scholarship, I don't think I would have had a reasonable quality of education. That's, that's, you see, you know, inequality there. That is something that bothers me.

It's very deep rooted. But you know, one must create awareness about it. What is legacy to you?

That's a big one. Legacy to me is more about impact. Not so much about accolades.

It's about the impact you have on people, on society. In a case, like say in the case of our family, it's more about impact through business. I think that's what creates legacy.

The way you connect with people, the way you give back to society, whether it impacts lives,

families in a direct way. That is a legacy to me. That's how we think of legacy.

I mean, that's what any of us, I think, in the family would think of when one talks of legacy.

[Speaker 2] (51:12 - 51:15)

Do you think generosity is a magnet for power?

[Speaker 1] (51:18 - 52:15)

You know, in a, are you saying in a corporate, in a corporate context, giving back is not generosity. I think it's just something that, look, you're taking from society and generating a profit, right? So giving a part of that back to society is something that for me and for all of us is a given.

It's not a big, big deal. I mean, it's something that you ought to be doing in the first place in any case. And why make such a big deal out of it?

It's almost a responsibility. You know, as we, as I look ahead globally, I think maybe after the church in some parts of the world or the government, of course, everywhere in the world, corporates are going to be one of the most important stakeholders globally, in every part of the world, practically. So that comes with the inherent responsibility.

[Speaker 2] (52:15 - 52:21)

Would you say that order is state, church, corporates? Church, I'm adding like all religions.

[Speaker 1] (52:21 - 54:34)

I think even if that were to be the case, I mean, that's always up for debate. But the point remains that corporates still are a very important and a growing part of society. And the expectation or the desire to give back is a responsibility.

And it's not really something that unusual or something that's altruistic. I mean, it's just something that should be done because you're just giving back to society from which the business, forget about the individual part of it, that, of course, also. But when you're getting so much, for business to play a role in impacting society positively is just part of a charter of business.

I don't think that it needs to be called out as philanthropy necessarily. That's how we would view it, which is why also we wouldn't talk about it, not for any other reason. But, you know, a lot of people have asked as to why there is no documentation on the work the family has done over the years, over generations.

And I did ask this to some of the family elders a few years ago. And obviously, no one was interested in doing that. I don't think there's anyone in the family today who knows about all the charities that have been done over the years in terms of contribution, you know, community asset

building.

And I think it would be great to document it just as an archival thing for the family, for our children and grandchildren. Obviously, no one in the family other than me believes there's merit to doing that, which is quite telling, actually. But there is no one who knows about everything that's been done in terms of giving back through the generations.

There are so many things you hear about. Go on a plant visit and there'll be people who come and say that yaha par yeh dharamshala hai jo aapne, aapke parivaar ki banayi hui hai.

[Speaker 2] (54:35 - 54:35)

Right.

[Speaker 1] (54:35 - 55:05)

And if I ask the family elders, none of them would sort of sometimes even know about it. So, I mean, it's a different way of giving. It's what some people would call gupt daan, which means it's really something that doesn't need to be talked about or revealed, so to speak.

It's just in the normal course of business, normal course of life.

[Speaker 2] (55:06 - 55:33)

Your family had a very interesting past with Mahatma Gandhi. Can you tell us more about that? He's such an enigmatic figure in our own country's history.

But not enough is spoken about him today, maybe. And if you had if you have any stories, any like interesting things that happened, he lived in your house in the last part of his life as well.

[Speaker 1] (55:34 - 58:20)

I mean, this was well before I was born, Nikhil. But, you know, essentially there is this socioeconomic concept of trusteeship, which my great grandfather, having spent so much time with him and being a close associate, came to embrace, which is that, you know, private companies in the private sector, so to speak, more it's more about collective prosperity as opposed to emblems of capitalism. Again, it comes back to the same topics that we were talking about.

Philanthropy is not about philanthropy, just about giving back. That concept of trusteeship has just percolated down the generations. Of course, one has heard about the time when he stayed in our family home, the day that he was shot.

And, you know, what happened after that, where people were. My grandmother remembered clearly where she was when this happened and how they all went rushing down, you know, all

the events that kind of happened after that. But I think the Gandhian way of living, there is still an element of that, that exists.

So, for example, you know, we would do a 10 minute puja for Diwali, 10 minute puja for Holi. I used to ask my, you know, my parents, why is it that we don't celebrate? So you celebrate if you want to, there's no harm.

But we don't believe in this thing of, you know, spending too much time on rituals, for example, a small thing. So there are sort of strong pieces of that legacy that also remain, which I find quite endearing, actually. Obviously, much less than before.

I mean, I remember my grandparents telling me, my grandaunts, how they lit a bonfire at the back of the house during the freedom movement. And they all sort of, you know, burned their clothes that they had, that were imported and started to wear khadi. Obviously, that passion doesn't sort of obviously stay the way it was at that point in time.

But I think that there are elements of that philosophy or that way of life, way of thinking that still, you know, come up every now and then within the family. And I think we're so fortunate for that.

[Speaker 2] (58:22 - 58:39)

Any like, if you were to describe him in three words, just the individual, not the public persona of all that we know about him, from a story that has been foretold in the family or has come down generations, how would you describe the man?

[Speaker 1] (58:40 - 59:13)

Mahatma Gandhi? That's a tough one. Liberal, I think.

Yeah, I mean, I think the influence that he had on my great-grandfather, therefore my family, would indicate to me that he was the one to be overly sort of cowed down by societal norms. Quite liberal in the way he thought. And that influence was something that rubbed off.

[Speaker 2] (59:13 - 59:15)

Anything else about him?

[Speaker 1] (59:17 - 59:57)

Not really, Nikhil. I mean, when you go to our family house, which is now, of course, owned by the government, you'll see that it was, you know, if you see his room, his chashma, book, you know, like a sort of a bed. Obviously, he believed in simplicity, not accumulating for himself at all.

Obviously, that's something that everyone knows about him. But yeah, I think he was quite liberal in his thoughts in many ways.

[Speaker 2] (59:58 - 1:00:32)

If we were to go back to the innate nature of human beings, and we say there is no such thing as true altruism, everybody gets some kind of a high. For the ones who don't get it from capitalism, it might be from being a contrarian, it might be a moralistic high, it might be that philanthropy gives somebody a high. Would you agree with that concept?

That we are all chasing a high, which only we can define for ourselves?

[Speaker 1] (1:00:33 - 1:00:34)

Give me an example.

[Speaker 2] (1:00:35 - 1:01:09)

Like if I were to find a person who does not believe in accumulating money, somebody who, I don't want to take the example of somebody who's not alive anymore, but somebody who's alive, who has dedicated his life to philanthropy, for example. Do you think that is appeasing his morality in such a way that it is giving a high which might be bigger than the high of capitalism even? Because it's rarer in today's capitalist society.

[Speaker 1] (1:01:09 - 1:01:45)

Good value. I mean, I guess it's a case to case situation, can't generalize. But if one has spent his or her life, you know, being philanthropic, chances are that they truly believe in that.

Which is why they live a life that they chose to live. Even if there is some element of making you feel, you know, like a high, if you're supporting people, you know, in whatever way that you are. I think that's fair.

I mean, how does that matter? That's just the human mind.

[Speaker 2] (1:01:46 - 1:01:50)

Fair. We'll go back to your high school. We went up until then in Bombay.

[Speaker 1] (1:01:50 - 1:01:50)

Yeah.

[Speaker 2] (1:01:50 - 1:01:55)

So 10 standard ICSE exams. Did well?

[Speaker 1] (1:01:56 - 1:01:57)

Very well, yeah.

[Speaker 2] (1:01:57 - 1:01:58)

And then college was?

[Speaker 1] (1:02:00 - 1:02:43)

Well, I went to junior college in Sydenham. Later in HR, I had started to study for my CA, even during the ICSE break. So I was studying for my CA alongside my graduation.

I actually became a CA six months after graduating. Which is quite hard. Which is very hard.

Not something that I enjoyed at all. I mean, that was a tough, tough phase of life because when your friends were having a relatively good time, you had to work pretty hard. Right.

[Speaker 2] (1:02:45 - 1:02:48)

And what was the driving factor to put in that work?

[Speaker 1] (1:02:48 - 1:02:49)

So my...

[Speaker 2] (1:02:49 - 1:02:49)

You didn't have to.

[Speaker 1] (1:02:49 - 1:03:16)

I didn't want to do a CA at all. I thought it was very dry, very boring. It's very tough.

It used to be. I mean, the pass percentage was, I think, two or three percent when I did it. So you can imagine the kind of stress it causes.

And I wasn't the kind of person who would get into it and not get out of it successfully. I'm the kind of person who would drop things midway.

[Speaker 2] (1:03:16 - 1:03:22)

Was that the weight of expectations and lineage or was that coming from inside?

[Speaker 1] (1:03:22 - 1:04:50)

It was just something my father was convinced that I needed to do a CA and an MBA. He pretty much, you know, set the agenda for my professional life at that time. Which I think was fair because he had a very good understanding of me, my strengths, my weaknesses, what my, you

know, likely work that I would do in the future would entail in terms of skill sets.

So essentially, he just said to me that if you're not going to be a CA, MBA, you can't come and work in our office. There's no role that I can give to you. And, you know, I just saw all my ambitions fly out of the window, right?

Because all the ambitions or whatever I had in terms of wanting to do things, create things were all related to business. That was my biggest exposure. I think that at our time, they used fear as a motivator every now and then, which I kind of understand now and didn't understand then.

But I figured quite easily that quite quickly that this was really something that I would have to do. I didn't have a choice. So it was a painful three or four or five years.

I just did it because I knew that that was my ticket to some of the things that I wanted to do in the future.

[Speaker 2] (1:04:52 - 1:05:45)

Do you think fear is a significantly larger, more powerful motivator than love, for example? I think Machiavelli says this. Machiavelli is like, I don't know, like Italian Chanakya, maybe if you were to like draw down an Indian analogy.

But when he was advising the Medicis and the Roman and the Florentine emperors of the time, he always said that as a leader, depict or influence fear among people is a far, will have a far longer tenure of rule, successful tenure of rule than if you were to show love to people. Because fear can be controlled and love cannot. What do you think about that?

[Speaker 1] (1:05:46 - 1:06:38)

I don't believe in that. I think fear is something that, for example, I wouldn't want my children to be fearful of anything unless they're doing something that's incorrect or unethical, which is not going to happen, just knowing the way they are. I don't think they need to be fearful.

Why fear? Fear is something that can really, you know, quash you as a personality. Why would you?

It's also a very different context, right? I'm talking about I was 22. That's about 35 years ago.

Parenting was a very different thing then, clearly. In today's context, I don't think that fear should have a role. I don't think it can have any kind of positive role to play in one's life.

[Speaker 2] (1:06:39 - 1:06:48)

You have a very kind way of explaining things. I read somewhere or someone said that you never lose your cool. You've lost it only twice.

[Speaker 1] (1:06:48 - 1:09:18)

I've lost it 18 times in 29 years. And the reason I remember this number so specifically is that to me, it's a black mark. If you're losing your cool, especially at work, you know, you're blessed to have so many colleagues who put in so much of their emotional, intellectual equity, their time.

Then for me to have to lose my cool is really not a very good commentary on me as a leader. Therefore, I've kept a count of it. Having said that, you know, sometimes it's important to be angry.

I mean, that's for the better. You need to be angry just to, you know, express a point of view that otherwise is sort of not going through or not getting registered as strongly as required. But yeah, I think that I'm a much easier person today than I was maybe even 10 years ago.

Even personally, I'm much less likely to lose my cool or lose my shirt over something. The chances of me just walking away from the situation are much higher. I think that's just learning from life.

It's also a lot of spirituality that you touched upon sometime back. I just think that getting angry is, unless it's something that, you know, and it depends on what I'm saying in the context of work, having to get angry is, it shouldn't happen very often. For me, it's not happened very often and it's worked.

There are tough conversations that you need to have and I've had several tough conversations on a one-to-one or with small teams. That's very different from getting angry. Getting angry in some way, let's say in a corporate context, it's also a little bit about getting out of control almost in my mind and therefore not a very good thing, the way I see it.

[Speaker 2] (1:09:20 - 1:09:21)

Are you somebody who...

[Speaker 1] (1:09:21 - 1:09:24)

You look like a very soft person and not someone who's going to get...

[Speaker 2] (1:09:24 - 1:09:25)

I never get angry.

[Speaker 1] (1:09:25 - 1:09:25)

Angry, yeah.

[Speaker 2] (1:09:25 - 1:09:27)

I can't remember the last time.

[Speaker 1] (1:09:28 - 1:09:29)

How do you do that?

[Speaker 2] (1:09:30 - 1:09:50)

I feel like my, how I arrived at not getting angry is a lot weaker than it is for you. I grew up around confrontation and I don't get angry because I want to avoid confrontation that comes with the anger.

[Speaker 1] (1:09:51 - 1:09:53)

But that's fair. I think that's a mature way to look at it.

[Speaker 2] (1:09:53 - 1:10:27)

So I'm actually escaping confrontation and you're likely very right that sometimes one has to be angry. But because I'm incapable of being angry, I'm somebody who's more, again, a weakness of mine, but passive aggressive. I would much rather ignore a person than confront the person which would have led for me to need to have been angry.

I don't cry much as well. I can count on my fingers how many times I've cried in the last decade.

[Speaker 1] (1:10:27 - 1:10:29)

How would the two be connected?

[Speaker 2] (1:10:32 - 1:11:05)

I feel like extreme emotion on one side is succumbing to the moment. The other side anger is, I think, trying to engulf the moment. So on those two extremes of that pendulum, I rarely go.

Like I said, five times. I remember brother stroke, dad, dog passing away, maybe one breakup. I can't even remember the fifth.

In the last decade.

[Speaker 1] (1:11:06 - 1:11:08)

That's quite something. That's unusual.

[Speaker 2] (1:11:08 - 1:11:11)

Yeah. Yeah, it is.

[Speaker 1] (1:11:11 - 1:11:14)

So you're very controlled in your emotions.

[Speaker 2] (1:11:15 - 1:11:23)

Fairly controlled, yeah. To the extent that people have called me emotionally dead. People who should not be calling me emotionally dead, if you know what I mean.

[Speaker 1] (1:11:24 - 1:11:29)

Is that worrying to you? It's not. It's done in a way that it is done by design.

[Speaker 2] (1:11:29 - 1:11:59)

No, no, it's not design. It's just circumstance. I use the excuse of work.

I tell myself that I have been an investor, trader for 21 years of my life. I started at 17 and 38 today. And there I do well by virtue of being non-emotional and not reacting, not emoting to something.

[Speaker 1] (1:12:00 - 1:12:02)

In work or even personally?

[Speaker 2] (1:12:02 - 1:12:03)

Even personally.

[Speaker 1] (1:12:03 - 1:12:05)

So you've trained yourself to be like that?

[Speaker 2] (1:12:05 - 1:12:20)

Yeah, I think so. Also, it's a very convenient excuse to me, for me. Yeah, so I use it.

Excuse for what? Excuse for when somebody comes asking, why are you emotionally like this?

[Speaker 1] (1:12:22 - 1:12:25)

You say that my work demands me to be like this.

[Speaker 2] (1:12:25 - 1:12:31)

I say that maybe my work has made me like this. I do get sad.

[Speaker 1] (1:12:31 - 1:12:35)

Could well be, right? I mean, work we do does shape us to an extent.

[Speaker 2] (1:12:35 - 1:12:36)

Yeah.

[Speaker 1] (1:12:36 - 1:12:38)

That's probably also a genuine reason.

[Speaker 2] (1:12:39 - 1:13:00)

I'm sure the work you do has shaped you. I mean, your work is 100 times bigger than my work. I think the nuances of it would have shaped your personality in so many ways.

The stresses of your life which led you to being the way you are today, only you will know. And I'm guessing you must have so many. How many people work under the umbrella now?

[Speaker 1] (1:13:02 - 1:13:05)

So across the group, we have 180,000 people.

[Speaker 2] (1:13:06 - 1:13:07)

That's like a country.

[Speaker 1] (1:13:09 - 1:13:27)

Yeah, but it's one team. That's the way we look at it, which it truly is. I mean, with a common purpose.

In some ways, everyone's pulling in the same direction. And that's a very energizing kind of environment to be in.

[Speaker 2] (1:13:28 - 1:13:39)

Okay, so we went to college. You became, you were a very precocious young man who did chartered accountancy much faster than should be humanly possible.

[Speaker 1] (1:13:41 - 1:13:42)

Say that again.

[Speaker 2] (1:13:43 - 1:13:46)

Six months faster than what was the time frame you said?

[Speaker 1] (1:13:47 - 1:13:56)

No, I was saying that I completed my CA within six months of graduating. Wow. Which, yeah, which was a tough one.

[Speaker 2] (1:13:57 - 1:13:59)

What was the proficiency there? Mathematics, was it?

[Speaker 1] (1:14:01 - 1:14:10)

I think the proficiency was just to be able to absorb a lot of things and retain that and kind of reproduce it.

[Speaker 2] (1:14:10 - 1:14:11)

Memory?

[Speaker 1] (1:14:11 - 1:14:25)

In an exam. Of course, memory, but it also is about just sheer volume and how well you retain that and understand that. That, of course, was the interesting part of it.

[Speaker 2] (1:14:27 - 1:14:32)

Is it like that even today? Are you able to retain an ordinate amount of information?

[Speaker 1] (1:14:32 - 1:14:46)

Yeah, less than before. But that's also part of my job since we're in so many different businesses. So I've trained myself a little bit to be like that also.

[Speaker 2] (1:14:47 - 1:14:49)

So after CA, next, what happened?

[Speaker 1] (1:14:50 - 1:15:04)

I mean, I got married, worked for my father. I was also working with my father while doing my CA, which meant just sitting next to him. It was like a real-time MBA.

[Speaker 2] (1:15:05 - 1:15:06)

Which part of the business?

[Speaker 1] (1:15:07 - 1:16:05)

So he had by then been detected with cancer. And in retrospect, I think he kind of re-pivoted the training program that he had for me after that. Made it quite smooth for me.

But he just wanted me to be with him through the day, sit through meetings, be in different situations. All kinds of businesses, even then, in a sense, some that were doing well, some that weren't doing well. Just to give me a sense of, you know, different businesses across the group, a more band group kind of exposure, which meant that I sat with him for eight, nine hours every day.

Quite tough, but I could see very quickly that there's lots to be learned here. What era was this?

[Speaker 2] (1:16:06 - 1:16:06)

Which year?

[Speaker 1] (1:16:08 - 1:21:54)

So this would be, you know, as part of your CA, you can intern with a company. And I chose to obviously do that with our company. So this was probably when I was 18.

So 85, I guess. It was an interesting time. I mean, very different time from now again.

And I remember that, I remember my mother, he used to complain to my mother quite often that I don't think Kumar pays attention. I used to tell her, you know, I'm sitting right under his nose, literally. I mean, I could almost pee on his lap.

And why on earth would I not pay attention? I mean, I'm, you know, I don't know. So this went on for a while, three or four times.

And eventually I told her, you know, we must ask him to stop and ask me about what's happening or my views or something about what's being discussed. Because that's the only way that he will know whether I'm paying attention or not. So he started to do that.

And fortunately, I obviously was paying attention and absorbing every bit of it. I kind of gave the impression that I was not being focused for some reason. But strangely, that changed my equation with him at work.

You know, he suddenly started, said to me, how is it that I thought you don't sort of pay attention, but you simply not seem to know pretty much what's happening. You absorb very fast. And so I said, you know, I'm almost a CA.

I'm going to be a CA in one year, so obviously, there has to be some advantage to that. That kind of was very reassuring to him. You know, he just said that I just feel that I had no idea that you learn so quickly.

And which was a huge thing for me at that point in my career, where my father was this huge, almost like a monster the first year that I worked with him. So that that was a huge shot in the arm. I think competing my CA was a big thing for me.

The last six months, I got a job offer at every company that I went to for an audit. They just knew me as Kumar and, you know, that was reassuring. My father got started to get a little worried, I thought.

You know, sort of like a way, but all of those things were positive, you know, positive signals to me. I grew in my confidence because of that. College, I couldn't really get to because I was either for two years, I was auditing the whole day.

Part of the CA, so every CA charter and every end of every term, I'd be outside the staff room and call your parents and all of that. I said, I'm doing my CA. I'd said that to you when I took admission.

I'm not, there's no way I'm calling my parents. If you really, really want me to do that, you give me my TC and I'm out of here. TC is transfer certificate.

So this drama went on almost for three years, unfortunately. They also kept saying, but we want to have you because, you know, it's such a matter of pride that one of our students is going to complete his CA along with graduation. But they also gave me this sort of tough deal after every kind of term.

My father wanted me to attend work and be with him. So it was quite a, you know, at the same time I was auditing outside firms, you know, every now and then. I remember three months, four months of going by train to Kandivali for an audit.

So life, there was lots of things happening. Quite overwhelming. But, you know, I had a deep sense that this is all going to work well for me.

So I'd kind of given up with my dad on the professional front. I figured that, you know, he has it sorted out and thought out much better than I could have ever done. So let me just follow what he said.

However tough it might be, and it was very tough. But I'm so grateful for that in retrospect because as things turned out, he passed away very early. I had a lot of responsibilities to take care of.

But yeah, interesting time. But very tough, a lot of hard work. And I don't think I've looked back in the sense that I think I've worked hard pretty much every day since then.

Other than when I'm on a holiday. I think that's pretty much a sort of bulwark of the kind of person I am. I've seen that growing up.

I had three generations before me going to work every day, intensely involved. My father and grandfather and great grandfather. And after that first initial years, just after I graduated and my CA, I think something that has stayed with me is the work, the fact that there really is no substitute for hard work.

For smart hard work. And I think that's a work ethic that I picked up from my family and I feel very grateful for that. Yeah, so it was a defining period of time for me.

[Speaker 2] (1:21:55 - 1:22:26)

How was it back then? I'm picturing 85, 86, pre-liberal India. You were 18 year old man going to work with his father.

Like paint a picture of your day back then. Where was the office? What was the scale of office?

What did it mean when you go to work? How did the employees of the office look at you? Can you throw some light?

I'm just trying to put a picture to it.

[Speaker 1] (1:22:30 - 1:24:08)

So I was like an intern, other than the fact that I was the owner's son. So I had the opportunity and privilege to sit right next to him. And like I said, it was like a real time MBA because I saw him in a tough situation.

I saw him conduct an AGM. I saw him firing someone. I saw him hiring some good people, attend to government issues.

That kind of exposure is something that you'd get over a period of time in your career. This was actually quite encapsulated because I think he knew somewhere that he was running out of time. And therefore he created this kind of encapsulated module for me to learn the different aspects of running a business.

So I was growing personally, professionally. It was a time of stress. I think very few would be able to take that kind of pressure.

But you know, like I said, I knew deep down that despite all the pain, it was well worth it. I was learning. I was in a very steep learning curve.

I couldn't have learned all of that sitting in college. I also worked for a year on the shop floor in a textile mill, which was quite fascinating. I wanted to understand about controls, financial controls, how manufacturing works, how you run a manufacturing business.

[Speaker 2] (1:24:08 - 1:24:10)

Right. This was at Grasim?

[Speaker 1] (1:24:11 - 1:25:10)

This was at Century Textiles that my grandfather owned and ran at the time. Now we've come to Nikhil when I'm last year of college. 22, 23, 20, 20 years of age.

So that's a lot of stuff happening for a 20 year old. A lot of my friends had, you know, I mean, they didn't, they weren't pushed the way I was being pushed. So they had a lot of free time.

They were having a good time generally. And that did pinch you at times, but they were very accommodating and, you know, adjusted things to, so that I could be a part of it. Yeah, so it was quite painful, but huge learning opportunity in some ways.

[Speaker 2] (1:25:11 - 1:25:13)

Do you have friends from back in the day who are still friends?

[Speaker 1] (1:25:13 - 1:25:32)

Oh, of course. I have three friends from back in the day who I'm in touch with on a regular basis. And thank God for that because there's such a huge support each in their own way.

You can be pretty much yourself. I mean, there are people who are known, their friends from school and college.

[Speaker 2] (1:25:33 - 1:25:35)

You can give them a shout out.

[Speaker 1] (1:25:36 - 1:26:33)

They know exactly that I'm talking about them. So yeah, that's a very important part of, you know, just having casual friendships from your school and college days, no strings attached, complete honesty, you know, fight sometimes, disagree vehemently with each other. We don't discuss work, not their work, not my work.

It's all about everything other than work. But we've been through a lot of ups and downs in life together, which obviously makes bonds much closer. I think it's very important having friends where it's a friendship that's not really seeking anything.

Makes life that much richer. Please. What about you?

[Speaker 2] (1:26:33 - 1:26:39)

I'm gonna have to. What do we start with?

[Speaker 1] (1:26:40 - 1:26:43)

I have my favorite sabji here, which is bhindi.

[Speaker 2] (1:26:43 - 1:26:43)

Yeah.

[Speaker 1] (1:26:44 - 1:26:48)

And I can go for days on end with having just bhindi and paneer.

[Speaker 2] (1:26:48 - 1:26:52)

Really? What is like a typical day of food for you?

[Speaker 1] (1:26:54 - 1:27:17)

I have small meals spread out through the day. I'm not someone who loves food. It's more eat to live kind of a thing.

Chocolate is something that, you know, I have a sweet tooth, especially with. Favorite chocolate? Keeps changing.

I mean, there's nothing.

[Speaker 2] (1:27:17 - 1:27:18)

Right now something.

[Speaker 1] (1:27:18 - 1:27:40)

Anything. Practically anything. These cravings happen after dinner.

So you almost start to feel like the workout I did didn't wasn't worth it because everything went up in calories. Yeah, but I'm a pretty frugal eater. Yeah, not too fussy about it.

What about you?

[Speaker 2] (1:27:41 - 1:28:05)

Um. So I like more protein, fiber, less carb kind of food. Today I burnt the top part of my mouth because my cook was getting engaged this morning and he was on a holiday.

So I made this particular dish, which I make whenever I have to cook.

[Speaker 1] (1:28:06 - 1:28:07)

South Indian dish?

[Speaker 2] (1:28:07 - 1:28:27)

No, it's like boiled rice with vegetables and chicken and no masala. Very simple. It's one pot.

You put some chicken. You put some vegetables. You put some rice.

You maybe add like some pepper and a couple of spices and you just eat it. It's really clean food. Makes you feel like great after eating it.

[Speaker 1] (1:28:30 - 1:28:32)

It's got protein and carbs both.

[Speaker 2] (1:28:34 - 1:28:38)

And no masala or oil or anything like that.

[Speaker 1] (1:28:38 - 1:28:44)

Hmm. So you burnt, you had it while it was too hot.

[Speaker 2] (1:28:45 - 1:29:02)

Yeah, I ate it off the stove, trying to taste if it's good. And I burnt not my tongue, but the upper part of my mouth. So bhindi and paneer for dinner and breakfast is?

[Speaker 1] (1:29:03 - 1:29:19)

Breakfast is a two egg omelette followed by soup sometime around 12 o'clock. Lunch, it's pretty simple. I think it's best to keep food simple.

[Speaker 2] (1:29:23 - 1:29:24)

Meals by yourself?

[Speaker 1] (1:29:29 - 1:29:51)

I reach home pretty late after work and a workout. So everyone else has eaten by then. But you know, all of us are around.

So I'm eating by myself, but the family is around. It's unlike the way it was at our time when everyone ate together. Can't be like that.

[Speaker 2] (1:29:52 - 1:29:55)

Are you a late to bed, wake up late kind of person?

[Speaker 1] (1:29:58 - 1:30:09)

I don't sleep too much, just five to six hours. So I sleep quite late, 1-1.30, wake up about 7.30. Yeah.

[Speaker 2] (1:30:11 - 1:30:13)

Typical weekend, what happens?

[Speaker 1] (1:30:15 - 1:30:51)

Saturdays I work till 5 o'clock. Weekends typically is for the kids and sometimes as the kids have grown older, last few years in particular, they have their own program, right? They have their own plans.

So interesting in a way it gives you more time to yourself. Yeah, there's nothing that's passed in stone at all.

[Speaker 2] (1:30:52 - 1:31:01)

What age is that when kids don't want to hang out with their parents and they want to hang out with their friends? 15, 16? Does it begin then?

I think so.

[Speaker 1] (1:31:02 - 1:31:17)

I mean, each child is different, but I think it's also important for them to have their own group of friends and sort of not hang out with parents all the time.

[Speaker 2] (1:31:18 - 1:31:24)

His son did very well at cricket, didn't he? Something he will pursue even in the future?

[Speaker 1] (1:31:25 - 1:32:31)

No, so he played professional cricket for seven years. After he played Ranji, he decided to give it up because all his decision to get into it, to get out of it because he felt that staying on would mean a lot more commitment in terms of time. And eventually he wanted to get into work.

So he worked with me for four years. He's now doing his MBA at Harvard. Finishes in May.

Yeah, but he had, I can see that there's a lot of learnings that he's carried from his days playing cricket. Yeah, attention span, ability to deal with all kinds of people. On time, always running

meetings on time of the day.

Very disciplined. Yeah, so I think it's shaped him as an individual.

[Speaker 2] (1:32:32 - 1:32:34)

Do you think sport helps business?

[Speaker 1] (1:32:36 - 1:32:37)

Sports help business.

[Speaker 2] (1:32:37 - 1:32:43)

In the sense that if you're good at a sport, it'll give you an added edge when you come to the corporate world.

[Speaker 1] (1:32:45 - 1:33:50)

Again, I think it's very person-specific, Nikhil. I mean, you can't generalize. In his case, it really did.

I'm sure he would have picked up some of these qualities even otherwise. But I think playing professionally for six, seven years, traveling all over the country, second class, non-AC train. I mean, he wouldn't need to do that, right?

If he wasn't playing some, I mean, wasn't in a spot like it. Staying in sort of back of the beyond places. You know, sort of being with people who are very different in terms of their backgrounds.

From him, most wouldn't even speak Hindi. But he, you know, made some good friends. I think that was a huge learning for him.

Started off when he did serving drinks, you know, to the players. And then went on to play Ranji. So it was quite an experience for him.

Very enriching, I could see.

[Speaker 2] (1:33:53 - 1:33:55)

Did you never consider buying an IPL team?

[Speaker 1] (1:33:55 - 1:33:56)

No.

[Speaker 2] (1:33:56 - 1:34:04)

No? Because? Do you like sport?

Do you like watching cricket?

[Speaker 1] (1:34:04 - 1:34:38)

Yeah, I mean, not cricket in particular. I'm not particularly a good sportsman. I couldn't understand the model of the IPL for the longest.

It's about capital allocation as well, right? I mean, when you have a lot of interesting opportunities before you, you've got to make choices. I'm not the sort of person, nor is my family or my son, the kind of person who would say, because I've been a cricketer, let's buy an IPL team.

Doesn't work like that.

[Speaker 2] (1:34:39 - 1:34:41)

Any sport you like outside of cricket?

[Speaker 1] (1:34:42 - 1:35:35)

So I've been, I've played different sports at different points in time, but never really pursued anything, unfortunately. The last, I've spent the most time on shooting. And I thought I'd play at least some kind of competitive level.

Didn't get to that. Not been shooting for the last two years because of a shoulder injury. But that's something that I find very interesting.

So my track, so to speak, is 10 meters pistol. And it just is so exciting. I mean, it just takes your mind away.

It gives you feedback as to how good a man you are, which I think is quite important to me. That's the reason why I like the sport. But I think it's just something you really enjoy.

[Speaker 2] (1:35:37 - 1:35:45)

So tomorrow, if the world were finding a more dystopian version of itself, you'd be good with a gun?

[Speaker 1] (1:35:48 - 1:36:11)

My God, it's not like I'm spending a lot of mind space or time on it. It's something that I enjoy doing, you know, and go to the range every now and then. Again, there's no regularity to it.

So no, it's not that kind of passion, but I really enjoy it when I'm out there.

[Speaker 2] (1:36:12 - 1:36:13)

Are you on social media?

[Speaker 1] (1:36:13 - 1:36:19)

No. No? You are a lot on social media.

What made you get onto it?

[Speaker 2] (1:36:21 - 1:36:30)

Not very active. I would post something maybe once in 10 days or something like that. Not much about my personal life, really.

[Speaker 1] (1:36:30 - 1:36:32)

So the objective is what?

[Speaker 2] (1:36:34 - 1:36:38)

The objective is getting more distribution.

[Speaker 1] (1:36:39 - 1:36:41)

More distribution? In what way?

[Speaker 2] (1:36:43 - 1:37:02)

The more number of people who follow you, or who are looking at what you're saying, is more... I'm not giving you the like superficial answer, but the real answer is it gives you more influence over a wider sect of society.

[Speaker 1] (1:37:04 - 1:37:11)

And what do you want to do with that influence? I mean, that's a very positive thing, but... How do you get it?

[Speaker 2] (1:37:12 - 1:37:57)

I don't know exactly what yet, but if I feel like something has to change in society, it gives me a good mouthpiece to say these contrarian things that maybe I think need to be said and other people are not saying it. Yeah, I do get into trouble for saying it. And I constantly change my mind about everything.

I go to the extent of thinking that authenticity itself is transient. My authentic self today is going to

be different from my authentic self tomorrow. So I do get called out for changing as often as I do.

But I feel like I was saying earlier, I think that change is necessary for evolution. If I were to...

[Speaker 1] (1:37:57 - 1:38:07)

Is changing all the time just being irrational? Or is changing because you have evolved, grown, and therefore you have a different point of view?

[Speaker 2] (1:38:08 - 1:38:15)

Changing because you have more evidence at hand, and now the pluses and minuses stack up on the other side.

[Speaker 1] (1:38:17 - 1:38:23)

But that's true for most people, right? With new experiences, your perspectives change.

[Speaker 2] (1:38:24 - 1:38:33)

Is there something that you believed in and committed to very strongly that you no longer believe in? Something from when you were younger?

[Speaker 1] (1:38:36 - 1:38:45)

No, I don't think... There's nothing I can call out. Is there something like that for you?

What sort of thing would you be referring to?

[Speaker 2] (1:38:48 - 1:39:19)

Even something like economic policy? There might have been times back in the day when I spoke for benevolent capitalism maybe being stretched as far as being known to be socialist. Now it doesn't make sense to me.

At some point, it felt like the right thing for society to do.

[Speaker 1] (1:39:20 - 1:39:22)

What made you change your point of view?

[Speaker 2] (1:39:23 - 1:39:24)

I think just more research.

[Speaker 1] (1:39:26 - 1:39:27)

Your own experiences, maybe.

[Speaker 2] (1:39:27 - 1:39:54)

I feel like in a family, you can be communist almost, if it's your family. With a group of friends, you can be communist. You can be socialist.

But as the group becomes wider, I don't think socialism works because trust factor falls very quickly. We don't trust people inherently that we do not know.

[Speaker 1] (1:39:55 - 1:39:56)

That we do not know.

[Speaker 2] (1:39:56 - 1:40:02)

Yeah, or have never seen. So socialism can work for 10 people, but I don't know if it can work for 10,000.

[Speaker 1] (1:40:03 - 1:40:15)

What makes you think about this? I'm really intrigued as to why would you think about this? There is something underlying that makes you want to know more about this.

[Speaker 2] (1:40:16 - 1:40:24)

I feel like the most interesting question in life is to figure out why we are how we are.

[Speaker 1] (1:40:25 - 1:40:26)

Like as individuals.

[Speaker 2] (1:40:27 - 1:40:53)

Individuals extrapolated down to society. I feel like I have no clue why I want what I want, why I do what I do. A large part is it to conform.

But outside of that, why did I become the person who thinks say he wants to do A, B or C? I have no idea. It comes from some interest in psychology and philosophy.

One of the two.

[Speaker 1] (1:40:54 - 1:41:02)

When you go back to your childhood, for example, you don't see any strain of connect with what you've done professionally?

[Speaker 2] (1:41:05 - 1:41:28)

Nothing. If I was 14 years old and you asked me, what do I want to become when I grow up? I said the most conformist thing of the time, which in my vintage was, I want to be an astronaut or a pilot or something like that.

But I can't paint a bridge from then to now.

[Speaker 1] (1:41:29 - 1:41:30)

Why would that bother you though?

[Speaker 2] (1:41:31 - 1:42:11)

It doesn't really bother me. If I were to leave my profession and all of that aside and think of very innately what I want as a person. Like if you would ask me, Nikhil, you're 38 today.

What do you want from life? Why are you the way you are today? It feels like an interesting thing to ponder about, spend some time dwelling on what made me the way I am.

And I think that's all psychology essentially. Every school of psychology...

[Speaker 1] (1:42:11 - 1:42:14)

You're thinking about more from the point of view of shaping your future or?

[Speaker 2] (1:42:15 - 1:42:15)

No.

[Speaker 1] (1:42:15 - 1:42:16)

Why do you think about it?

[Speaker 2] (1:42:16 - 1:42:37)

Just understanding the present. I don't think I can ever shape my future or change something about me that already exists. If I'm petty, I'm going to remain petty.

If I'm jealous, I'm going to remain jealous. If I'm insecure, I'm going to remain insecure.

[Speaker 1] (1:42:38 - 1:42:45)

Why do you feel that way? People do change, right? Circumstances change people.

New exposures change people.

[Speaker 2] (1:42:46 - 1:43:13)

I feel like if it's a mask, you can change it inherently. If that's a trait in you, I think it's hard to change. I don't want to change anything.

I don't want the contradiction of having to make an effort in saying I was petty. I must not be petty. I don't want to make that effort and I don't think I can.

But I just want awareness of why I am petty and how I got to be petty.

[Speaker 1] (1:43:15 - 1:43:16)

What would you do with that?

[Speaker 2] (1:43:17 - 1:43:28)

Nothing. Just know. Yeah.

Just the awareness. I don't think there's anything I can do with it.

[Speaker 1] (1:43:28 - 1:43:34)

Is there a learning for the future or what would you do by just knowing?

[Speaker 2] (1:43:35 - 1:43:52)

I think I would just understand life a little bit better. If I'm able to figure out why I am the way I am, it will just give me a little bit more understanding about life. And I think that's all I'm hoping for.

It's a really big question for me, actually.

[Speaker 1] (1:43:53 - 1:43:53)

Which is?

[Speaker 2] (1:43:55 - 1:44:03)

Why I am the way I am. These are interesting questions that I don't know if I'll ever have the answer to, but I can ponder about.

[Speaker 1] (1:44:04 - 1:44:27)

Yeah. You're a very introspective person, Nikhil. I mean, I'm quite amazed at how many things you think so deeply about.

Is that something that you've always done? Or is it something that it's a trait that you picked up from your parents? Or is that just you enjoy doing that?

[Speaker 2] (1:44:27 - 1:44:39)

Enjoy doing it, I think. Not like I found any answers. I probably have more questions than I began with, but it keeps me occupied.

[Speaker 1] (1:44:40 - 1:44:50)

You have lots of things on the work front, right? To keep you occupied. When do you get the time to think so deeply about so many different things?

[Speaker 2] (1:44:51 - 1:45:58)

I have enough time. I've realized that most of what I do is pretend to work. I had this conversation with somebody at some point of time.

It's slightly different for a lot of people. But one day I was sitting in my office and having this conversation with some CXO of our company, my brother and a couple other guys. And we all started saying this one after the other.

One is like, okay, I pretend to work X hours a day. Out of the insecurity of knowing you're sitting in front of me and pretending to work. I don't think I do productive work for more than, I don't know, It's quite complex.

Maybe like 90 minutes a day. And that would be pushing it. The rest of the time is very repetitive work.

And if I were to ask myself the question that I'm excusing my persona from that situation, how much would change? The answer most often that comes back to me is not much.

[Speaker 1] (1:45:59 - 1:46:00)

Not much would change if?

[Speaker 2] (1:46:01 - 1:46:05)

If I was not there for very many things.

[Speaker 1] (1:46:05 - 1:46:11)

Is that because the business has got to grow and doesn't require so much of your attention?

[Speaker 2] (1:46:11 - 1:46:45)

No, no, it's not that. I feel like there are smarter people out there who are better positioned to make many of the decisions I make than me. And it is my ego which has gotten swollen up by virtue of the accidents in life and has gotten me to this point where, you know, everybody like,

they're not like you guys.

I mean, you guys are a hundred times bigger, but even at my scale. Invariably, you get surrounded by so many yes men.

[Speaker 1] (1:46:45 - 1:46:49)

That sounds like you're ready to start a new business.

[Speaker 2] (1:46:50 - 1:46:55)

You think? Yeah. Clearly no.

[Speaker 1] (1:46:58 - 1:46:59)

Is that true?

[Speaker 2] (1:46:59 - 1:47:16)

No. No. It just sounds like, I think, I don't know what I want, but I know a little bit more about what I don't want.

[Speaker 1] (1:47:17 - 1:47:17)

In terms of work?

[Speaker 2] (1:47:21 - 1:47:37)

I don't want to waste any more of my life pretending to work. The productive work that I do, I will do. And the rest of the time I can utilize in learning and reading and exploring and doing things I actually cherish doing.

[Speaker 1] (1:47:38 - 1:47:41)

So you're saying you're pretending to work for whose benefit?

[Speaker 2] (1:47:42 - 1:48:10)

Nobody's benefit, but for the insecurity of when you're in an ecosystem, say there's four of you sitting together, because the other three are pretending, I'm also pretending. And I feel like a lot of the world is going to go there with all the evolution that's happening in tech. I think most people will be pretending to work a lot more than they were pretending to work yesterday.

[Speaker 1] (1:48:13 - 1:48:15)

Because of social media?

[Speaker 2] (1:48:15 - 1:48:22)

Because of also tech making their jobs far more efficient if they so choose to utilize it.

[Speaker 1] (1:48:23 - 1:48:32)

That's quite unfortunate, don't you think? So much of pretense and pretense about working when you can do so many better things in that same time.

[Speaker 2] (1:48:32 - 1:48:50)

But I think that's been society from the beginning of time. I feel like in that hierarchy, every manager does lesser than the people he manages. And every manager's manager does lesser.

It's actually like inversely proportional to the reward they get for the work.

[Speaker 1] (1:48:53 - 1:49:17)

Could be because they've grown up up the ladder, right? They've been in a situation where their subordinates were or are. And they've gone through that rigor.

That's quite possible, I think. So is your work pretty close to where you live or your office?

[Speaker 2] (1:49:17 - 1:49:18)

Yeah, it's not far.

[Speaker 1] (1:49:19 - 1:49:22)

I guess that's the way to walk around the situation, right?

[Speaker 2] (1:49:22 - 1:49:29)

Yeah, you can have that. I think you like dark chocolate?

[Speaker 1] (1:49:29 - 1:49:30)

Yeah.

[Speaker 2] (1:49:36 - 1:49:55)

Okay, so we were at, you started interning. You go back there. And then what happened next?

We're in the year 86, 87, something like that.

[Speaker 1] (1:49:55 - 1:52:10)

Yeah, I think. Yeah, so I'm working with my father, complete my graduation and my CA. You know, it's a lot of work.

But good work, I mean, it's good. You get wrapped on the knuckles once in a way. But you learn to sort of accept that as a way of life.

Also, you know, the intent is right. I also started looking at some of the units independently. And I feel a great sense of almost like gratitude because all my friends, I mean, their fathers treated them like they were nothing on earth.

And if I got the opportunity to have independent charge of fertilizer unit and a cement unit, that really meant a lot. That was huge learning. Different time, I mean, my father and I would sit at the end of every month and he would analyze, want me to analyze all the breakdowns that happened in the three, four cement plants that we had.

It was quite painful, but it was relevant because at that time you sold what you made. Right. There wasn't anything, any other variable that was important.

But it just be very boring and nice to see to myself, you know, I want to have so many kills that Baba Khan asked me to be doing this every month. It was just such a boring thing to do. But yeah, it was like I said, steep learning curve.

I got married in 89, went off to my MBA after that at London Business School, which was again, huge learning and very transformation in some ways.

[Speaker 2] (1:52:10 - 1:52:11)

That was post marriage?

[Speaker 1] (1:52:12 - 1:52:13)

That was post marriage.

[Speaker 2] (1:52:14 - 1:52:17)

It says that you only met your wife three or four times pre marriage.

[Speaker 1] (1:52:18 - 1:52:26)

Yeah, I mean, that's what, that's how it happened. Twice, not even three or four times.

[Speaker 2] (1:52:26 - 1:52:26)

Yeah.

[Speaker 1] (1:52:28 - 1:52:30)

So it was quite tough on both of us.

[Speaker 2] (1:52:30 - 1:52:31)

Isn't that really awkward?

[Speaker 1] (1:52:31 - 1:52:54)

It really is. But, you know, at that time in our community, for sure. That's how things, that's how, you know, marriages happen.

That was just the norm and you just kind of flowed with the time.

[Speaker 2] (1:52:57 - 1:52:59)

Okay. And then you went off to college in London.

[Speaker 1] (1:52:59 - 1:53:25)

Went to college. Studied business. No, London Business School.

Good two years, great learning. Met a lot of different kinds of people from across the world. Come back.

In another couple of years, my father got detected with cancer and then passed away. Soon after that. So life changed quite dramatically.

[Speaker 2] (1:53:25 - 1:53:27)

Travelled alone or like with family back to college?

[Speaker 1] (1:53:29 - 1:53:30)

Me? With family.

[Speaker 2] (1:53:30 - 1:53:31)

Like with wife?

[Speaker 1] (1:53:32 - 1:53:34)

With wife. We were together when I was studying.

[Speaker 2] (1:53:35 - 1:53:40)

So came back. Dad was ill. Immediately joined the business.

[Speaker 1] (1:53:41 - 1:53:58)

I was in any case working completely with him, right? Even while you were in college? Not in college, no.

But, you know, it was just the natural thing to do. Come back and join him. And pick up, you know, sort of start up from where I left.

[Speaker 2] (1:54:01 - 1:54:06)

And is there a part of the business that you joined first?

[Speaker 1] (1:54:06 - 1:55:00)

I cut my teeth in textile. Like I said, spent a year on the shop floor. I just felt that it's the most complex business that you've been at that point in time.

And therefore, it would be the best learning round for me. Most other businesses were easier to understand and run as compared to textiles then. Cement was the other business that, you know, I was exposed to.

Ran a unit. Chemicals business, caustic soda plant. And I said it was a small plant.

But, you know, leadership experiences, invaluable. Dealing with people with all very new for me, right? Bit like being Alice in Wonderland almost.

[Speaker 2] (1:55:02 - 1:55:14)

Was that the only game in town back then? Because even when I read, say, your peer group stories, like Reliance and all of them, everybody did textiles in that era. That was the biggest business in India?

[Speaker 1] (1:55:14 - 1:55:16)

That was one of the biggest businesses.

[Speaker 2] (1:55:17 - 1:55:18)

In the 80s?

[Speaker 1] (1:55:20 - 1:55:23)

80s. Maybe up until the early 90s as well.

[Speaker 2] (1:55:24 - 1:55:25)

Until India opened up?

[Speaker 1] (1:55:25 - 1:55:26)

Correct.

[Speaker 2] (1:55:27 - 1:55:42)

And how did it feel living in that India? Like I've read about it. I was too young to be cognizant to it.

I must have been like five, six years old in 91. How did it feel? What changed on the ground?

[Speaker 1] (1:55:44 - 1:55:55)

I was quite absorbed with what I was doing, actually, Nikhil. So you didn't know any better. It's when India started to open up to the world.

[Speaker 2] (1:55:55 - 1:55:59)

And when you say open up, can you elaborate? What happened when you say open up?

[Speaker 1] (1:56:00 - 1:56:35)

So tariffs started to come down. You had foreign investors coming into the market in India and investing in your company. Therefore, investor expectations were different because their profile was very different.

You know, it was much more competitive. Tariffs came down in India. You had competition literally at the back door.

Therefore, the whole dynamic of running a business changed. You had to think about strategy, about people, needed new kind of talent. So it was quite a metamorphosis at that point in time.

[Speaker 2] (1:56:38 - 1:56:41)

And did you get an investor into your business?

[Speaker 1] (1:56:44 - 1:57:12)

No, when I say investor, I mean, they were also investing through the market, right? So the profile of investors who are invested in your company. You don't have private equity really back then the way you have it now.

But when you have a different investor pool investing in the company, then, you know, investor expectations start to change. You become more accountable. Investors become more vocal.

[Speaker 2] (1:57:14 - 1:57:21)

What do you think of private equity in venture capital today? It's very prevalent in my world, the startup world of today.

[Speaker 1] (1:57:21 - 1:57:50)

I think it's a very credible way of building assets or building businesses. A different world, quite different from the world of business that I'm in, so to speak. It requires a different kind of skill set almost.

But yeah, I think it's a huge source of equity today and capital. And it's a very credible way to grow a business.

[Speaker 2] (1:57:51 - 1:58:02)

Do you think private equity and venture funds today are a bit like the money lenders and zamindars of yesterday?

[Speaker 1] (1:58:04 - 1:58:05)

I don't think so.

[Speaker 2] (1:58:05 - 1:58:06)

No?

[Speaker 1] (1:58:07 - 1:58:09)

Why would you connect the two?

[Speaker 2] (1:58:10 - 1:59:03)

When I think about it, I feel like that. I mean, I do a little bit of both of those things. But whenever a private equity venture guy invests into your company, they have terms which mean that in case of liquidation, they get their money first.

Different clauses that make you share your upside. You know, there's venture debt and a whole bunch of nuances there. But in many ways, it feels like somebody who made money somewhere.

In case of PE and venture, it might be like, I don't know, LP sitting out of America. It might be some endowment fund. It might be some pension fund.

Money coming from somewhere, finding a higher rate of return. There's a lot of commonalities between that and how a money lender of yesterday has worked.

[Speaker 1] (1:59:07 - 1:59:10)

But you sign up to it, right? With your eyes and ears open. So it's fair.

[Speaker 2] (1:59:11 - 1:59:12)

As you did with the money lender.

[Speaker 1] (1:59:13 - 1:59:17)

I think that's a bit of a harsh view on private. You've had a bad experience?

[Speaker 2] (1:59:17 - 1:59:21)

No, no, I have. We've never raised any capital in India.

[Speaker 1] (1:59:21 - 1:59:32)

Hmm. No, I think it's a lot of it is about chemistry also. Eventually, I think.

No, I think you're taking a pretty harsh view on them.

[Speaker 2] (1:59:33 - 2:00:11)

Yeah. No, I'm not being harsh. I feel like they've served a very useful purpose of marketing the India story outside of India.

In order to bring foreign capital into India. And it has subsidized consumption for a lot of people in India. We paid lesser for our taxis, paid lesser for food delivery.

Paid lesser for so many things and industries grew in India on their backs. So I'm not saying it's a bad thing. I'm just wondering.

If in a certain way, even money lenders yesterday did similar things.

[Speaker 1] (2:00:12 - 2:00:47)

I mean, there were atrocities happening back then. These guys are what? They're demanding investors.

Like I said, you pretty much sign up to what they're expecting. You need to align expectations. I mean, but you know, they have their own.

You have the laws of the land that govern them as well. So if you're signing up to an agreement that's, you know, one sided, then that's something that you're knowingly signing up to.

[Speaker 2] (2:00:48 - 2:01:05)

If you had one chance to redo life today, starting afresh. You're not Kumar Mangalam Birla, but you're just Kumar starting off. And you have X amount of capital, let's say a million dollars.

What business would you put the money in?

[Speaker 1] (2:01:05 - 2:01:18)

Today? Today. I mean, there are many of them that that's always a problem that there's a problem of plenty.

One. Difficult to boil down to one.

[Speaker 2] (2:01:18 - 2:01:22)

You're making bets on paints and jewelry.

[Speaker 1] (2:01:23 - 2:01:24)

Jewelry retail.

[Speaker 2] (2:01:25 - 2:01:25)

Why?

[Speaker 1] (2:01:27 - 2:03:15)

So different reasons. Paints because, you know, the industry is moving from being unorganized to more organized. Real estate is looking up after COVID.

People want their own homes. The nuclear family set up in India is kind of giving way to the joint family setup is giving way to nuclear families. Aspirational Indian wants their own home.

Home is a sense of achievement, a sense of pride. We also have an overlap with the existing cement business in terms of the dealership network, which is one of the key success factors required in something like paints. So all of that gives us a right to win, so to speak.

Jewelry retail, because we've been in the retail space for almost 25 years now. So we understand it fairly well, but that's apparel retail. So doing another form of retail is, you know, logical.

You then go by empirical evidence of which sector is doing well and for what reason. Jewelry because, again, it goes back to an aspirational India. People want to feel good, look good.

There's really only one national level player. You have a couple emerging. But since one of the objectives that we have very clearly marked out for ourselves when we get into a new business is that we want to be in a leadership position, which means number one, number two, at worst, number three, the foreseeable future.

It ticks the sort of box on that one as well.

[Speaker 2] (2:03:16 - 2:03:17)

Still 95% unorganized.

[Speaker 1] (2:03:19 - 2:03:52)

Jewelry, I don't know the percentage, but it is something, you know, it is a sector that's only now becoming more organized in the last few years, I think. So that's an opportunity. It's also the trust associated with the brand.

I'm quite surprised in the first month we had a thousand people who came with, you know, their gold jewelry and exchanged it for stuff from our store, which I thought was an interesting insight. So trust obviously plays a very important role in this business.

[Speaker 2] (2:03:53 - 2:03:56)

Do you have an opinion on lab-grown diamonds and what's happening in the diamond market?

[Speaker 1] (2:03:57 - 2:04:51)

Not really. I mean, I know that the value of diamonds has gone down by about 20% in the last one year, which is, you know, quite stark. In India too, jewelry doesn't seem to be only investment class of asset.

It's also just for aspirational and for the optics of it. Um, which makes it, you know, it's a different business than what it would have been, say, even 10 years ago. But obviously there's a different market for lab-grown diamonds.

And it is growing very fast from what I understand. It's not our space, but it is something that's going to, you know, take up some demand from, you know, retailers of precious jewelry.

[Speaker 2] (2:04:52 - 2:04:54)

It's something that you want to explore?

[Speaker 1] (2:04:54 - 2:05:03)

Not sure. We just, I think we first need to consolidate here. And it's always an option.

[Speaker 2] (2:05:04 - 2:05:16)

What if a young entrepreneur had lesser money, like say one crore rupees or two crore rupees and wanted to start a business? Is there an industry you think that has so much tailwind that they should really focus on?

[Speaker 1] (2:05:17 - 2:05:24)

So one crore is just, it's just not enough to start any business in today's context. I'd rather just keep it in the bank.

[Speaker 2] (2:05:25 - 2:05:27)

What if it was 10 and not one?

[Speaker 1] (2:05:30 - 2:05:44)

I mean, hypothetical, but again, not so much that you can do. I mean, we're talking about in India where, you know, scale is important. How much can you do with 10 crores?

You see, what would you do with 10 crores?

[Speaker 2] (2:05:45 - 2:05:49)

Me? I can start a jewelry store with 10 crores.

[Speaker 1] (2:05:50 - 2:05:52)

Jewelry store would be more than that. I think it's about 30 crores.

[Speaker 2] (2:05:53 - 2:05:56)

Yeah, like a large one. Like a smaller one I could, right?

[Speaker 1] (2:05:57 - 2:06:00)

Depends on what's the plan.

[Speaker 2] (2:06:00 - 2:06:05)

Maybe a lab-grown jewelry, lab-grown gold, low value jewelry. Yeah, sure.

[Speaker 1] (2:06:06 - 2:06:07)

That could be interesting.

[Speaker 2] (2:06:07 - 2:06:09)

Right? Like try to build a brand of it.

[Speaker 1] (2:06:11 - 2:06:15)

Then scale on the back of the brand. Is that what you're suggesting? Yeah.

[Speaker 2] (2:06:16 - 2:07:22)

Like the novelty will be a brand in the beginning, right? If I can only make jewelry which costs 50,000 rupees and lower and use lab-grown and gold. Maybe the affordability.

The one thing I feel is broken in jewelry stores is whenever people go shopping, it could be a married couple. It could be, say, a father-daughter. The experience of walking into a jewelry store is very overwhelming and daunting.

Because often, whoever you're taking there to buy them something can pick something that you can't afford. So if there were a jewelry store with a ceiling, let's say, for example, nothing costs more than one lakh rupees. Almost like a dollar store, but like in a different way.

I feel the experience of going in there and shopping might be less overwhelming. But it can't be sold like a budget thing.

[Speaker 1] (2:07:22 - 2:07:34)

So that's almost like a studio in the context of apparel. And we'll have to try it out. Quite interesting.

Right? I think. But it's a different business case altogether.

[Speaker 2] (2:07:39 - 2:07:43)

Anything else you think like advice to young entrepreneurs? What should they do now?

[Speaker 1] (2:07:45 - 2:08:25)

Advice to young entrepreneurs? Do what you love doing. Keep the passion going.

Get together a great team. That's most important. I mean, it's a team that achieves.

You can be a good leader, but without a good team, there's not much that you can do. You know, being just one single person. I'd say consistency.

Learning agility is very important. There's so much of change in the world today that to stay current and tweak your business model on the basis of what's happening in the world today.

[Speaker 2] (2:08:26 - 2:08:59)

How do you change like you did? Like you went from textiles to cement to like trying jewelry and paints today. And these are all like completely different things.

Even someone like us, like, you know, we've been doing broking and asset management for a bit or lending. We don't find it in ourselves to be able to change. But people like you,

intergenerational families who pivot so easily.

What are you doing that we are unable to do?

[Speaker 1] (2:09:00 - 2:10:24)

No, I'm not sure you're unable to do it. It's just that you haven't maybe reached that situation. It is, you know, it does cause you to need you to stress more, stretch more.

But I think there's also a sense of excitement around that. So as India is growing up or grew up, new spaces opened up for private enterprise, right? For example, financial services is a case in point.

There was a point in time, I think around 95, 97, when the AMC mutual funds started to open up for private sector, then insurance. You don't want to miss that opportunity. So on and so forth, even with retail.

At the end of the day, there is a national, a trend at least national level, if not international, that you are hooking up to. It's also a call on whether you want to be a conglomerate or, you know, one or two businesses. And we took a call very early on, I did, that we've grown up being a conglomerate and we have strengths in running different businesses.

And doing that successfully. And that's what we'd like the future paths to be like.

[Speaker 2] (2:10:25 - 2:10:32)

If I can ask you a very personal question, how do you know it is the time to pivot? What do you feel in a certain business?

[Speaker 1] (2:10:33 - 2:11:01)

In a certain? Business. I think you have, you get a sense that now this business is mature enough.

It's because you've been, you know, you're sort of growing with the business, your own understanding of the business, you know, gets deeper and deeper. It's a feel, it's an instinct. I think an entrepreneurial, entrepreneur's instinct is a huge factor in this.

[Speaker 2] (2:11:02 - 2:11:10)

So when you feel a business is mature enough, you pivot and you put your energy behind the new thing. And how does the old ship keep sailing?

[Speaker 1] (2:11:11 - 2:11:50)

It's not always like that. I mean, that makes it sound very mechanical. But I think that's, you know,

that's something that even if it isn't in a conglomerate situation, if you have mature businesses that have sort of reached a cycle where growth rates are tapering, you need to invest in new engines of growth.

And essentially, that's the model that we have followed. If you look back and study, there's no brilliance, you know, attached to it. It's just common business sense.

[Speaker 2] (2:11:51 - 2:11:53)

How do you step back and let somebody else run the old ship?

[Speaker 1] (2:11:54 - 2:13:25)

Well, not the old ship, every ship, because like I was saying, we're 180,000 people. My daughter is involved in some businesses, my son as well. But you know, for the longest, it's just been me now with my kids.

Obviously, it's not a family run business. It's basically a people run business. It's a people's organization.

I think if you, I mean, trust is a very important factor, that there's something in your DNA which must allow you to trust people. You also then obviously need to need to choose the right people. And there's some method there, I think.

I think if you have ambition, like when I, in 95, when I started out, I had ambition and I had limited experience. My father had just passed away. And logically, the only way I could build bandwidth, and that stays true even today, was by getting people with more experience on board and with different talents that talent skill sets that we had in the organization.

So I think it's also to do with ambition and passion. And if you want to grow, the only way to grow is to have energized teams. I mean, there is no, you know, there is no other way out.

And that's the fundamental principle on which we're working.

[Speaker 2] (2:13:26 - 2:13:36)

I feel like I have a lot to learn from you in this. Is there something you look for in people when you're doing this pivot? From the people you're hiring?

Is there something?

[Speaker 1] (2:13:36 - 2:15:01)

So there's two kinds of people, those who've grown up in the organization. So I have about 4,000 people who've been with me for 20 plus years. With people like that, you know them pretty much.

I mean, I don't, I may not know all of them, but HR would, other people in the system would. So that's, that's, you know, being a meritocracy. You have a track record within the company.

And meritocracy means that you're pretty much getting ahead basis the merit that you want for yourself. For people from outside, it's a gut feel. You look at their track record, you speak to them, you do sound referencing.

It's a gut feel. I mean, you think, I look at people and I ask myself, can they handle complexity? Are they agile learners?

And would they be able to lead large and diverse teams of people? And that, that sense you can only get with talking to them, right? There's no other way.

So I think more than just referencing, it's about your own instinct, right? Your own experience with different kinds of profiles of people. So it is a leap of faith at the end of the day.

[Speaker 2] (2:15:04 - 2:15:26)

They say that when people are on their deathbed, the things that they often regret are things like, why did I work so hard? Why did I worry about how I'm being perceived? Why didn't I spend time with my friends?

Stuff like that. What do you think it will be for you? What would be the regret?

[Speaker 1] (2:15:27 - 2:17:04)

I mean, I don't know, to be honest, I don't know if there are going to be regrets. I mean, but I think that especially in the last 15 years, I'd say I've lived life quite thoughtfully. And I mean, life's been kind.

I've had more challenges. Life has thrown me more curveballs on the left side than I can even sort of talk about it. Anyone could even imagine.

But, you know, there have been so many things on the positive side as well. So one feels a sense of gratitude. I don't think at this point of time, if I was to be on my deathbed today, I don't think there's anything I'd hugely regret.

I mean, I've never had, for example, a work-life balance, but that's been my choice for various reasons, right or wrong. It's not happened by default. There have been reasons behind it, which to me are logical, well thought through.

I don't think that there is any such regret I would have. Of course, if I have another 30 years to live, at least the situation might change. But yeah, I mean, God's been kind.

I don't I don't have any, I mean, regret would be, for example, I wish my father was there for

longer. That's not something you regret at the end of life. I mean, that's your regret is about to do with life choices that you have made.

So I think so far it's gone well.

[Speaker 2] (2:17:06 - 2:17:13)

I think that's it. We've covered all that we wanted to today. Thank you for doing this.

[Speaker 1] (2:17:13 - 2:17:27)

No, it's been interesting. You're doing a great job of this. I know a lot of people watch your podcasts and, you know, I'm sure draw inspiration from them.

[Speaker 2] (2:17:27 - 2:17:40)

Any fleeting words to the many young entrepreneurs who will be so inspired by watching this? Anything that you want to tell them, which is non-obvious? Someone looking to start?

[Speaker 1] (2:17:40 - 2:18:00)

I think the power of consistency, the soft power of consistency, something that we don't always value. That's, in my experience, very important. As you grow in your careers, you start to realize that it's good to know that early on.

[Speaker 2] (2:18:02 - 2:18:06)

Nice. Thank you so much for doing this and taking the time with us.

[Speaker 1] (2:18:06 - 2:18:06)

It's been a pleasure.

[Speaker 2] (2:18:08 - 2:18:18)

Thanks, guys. Thanks, everyone. Is it OK?

Yeah, yeah. You shot quite a bit. You're quite an intense guy.

Three and a half months.

[Speaker 1] (2:18:21 - 2:18:26)

But it's good, I think. Nice to watch you up. Huh?

You think so much. Wow.